



## Speeding along on dung!

The UK's waste powered bus set a new speed record for fastest service bus at 123.5kmph  
<http://digit.in/1Hog7tE>



## Floppy music

An Arduino board and 49 floppy drives were combined to make an Organ! <http://digit.in/1e1YtQt>

## Know Your Meme: The Wikipedia of memes

Unfortunately, creating successful memes isn't as easy as browsing to a meme generator and creating one from a choice of templates. Memes are spread socially from user to user, much like a virus. This also explains why popular memes are said to have gone viral. And just like a virus, memes tend to have a lifespan that's characterised by a certain point where the infection is at its peak. Therefore, making an informed choice on a meme requires research. The online meme resource, Know Your Meme, is arguably the best source for meme-specific research. Best described as the Wikipedia of memes, this handy website effortlessly breaks down the basics of any meme.

It gives a crucial insight into the underlying context of a meme by documenting its origin, spread, and timeline. This should be your go-to resource for demystifying any meme and understanding how it works. To put it simply, you can't successfully co-opt a new meme unless you familiarise yourself with it on Know Your Meme first. The best part is that this website also provides a handy search trend analysis chart. This data is important because it shows whether the Internet still has any interest in the particular meme. To ensure success, you're essentially looking for a meme that's still relevant.

## Photoshop vs Online Meme Generators

Now that you know how to select an exploitable meme, it's time to take a look at the best ways to do so. There are plenty of online meme generators that let you create your own version of a popular

meme with just a few clicks. Imgur's meme-specific tool, memegen, is a hit with Reddit users. It's one of the quickest and no-nonsense means of creating a meme that uses the website's acclaimed clutter-free UI. Users have the option of either browsing through a comprehensive list of memes or simply selecting one from the drop-down menu. Thereafter, the tool provides the option to add text in order to customise the meme. Additionally, users can add their own images to create an entirely new meme from scratch. Once done, the image is uploaded directly to Imgur, from where it can be shared on Reddit or other social networking websites.

Quickmeme is one of the oldest online meme generation tools and it was the website of choice for Reddit users until it was caught and subsequently banned from Reddit for manipulating votes for self-promotion. It is similar in functionality to Imgur's memegen tool, but it's marred by the presence of watermarks and incompatibility with Reddit. Meme-Dad is a great alternative to Quickmeme. It incorporates the same features without the annoyance of watermarks or a Reddit ban.

Most meme purists, however, do not prefer online tools at all. This kind doesn't appreciate the watermarks and the general rigidity entailed by these easy-to-use tools. Some meme makers like to customise their creations by using images of varying sizes, relying on non-standard fonts and placement, and other means of creating bespoke meme implementations. This kind of user prefers image-editing tools such as Photoshop and GIMP. The only relatively complicated aspect of

process is recreating the typical outlined meme font style.

Going about it is deceptively simple in Photoshop. After loading your base image, create a text layer at the top and bottom.



Use the Impact font to fill in the text, making sure that you use all caps. With the text entered, navigate to the Layer tab and hover the mouse pointer on Layer Styles. Select Outer Glow, which will open up a window. Use it to change the effect's colour to black. Choose Hard Light in the Blend Mode option. Set the thickness of the outline according to your preference. That's pretty much all you need to create a meme without the aid of online tools.

## A Scientific Approach

Now that you are armed with the knowledge of selecting and creating memes for success, it would be a good idea to refine the process with a bit of science. Yes, computer scientists from Stanford University have tried their hand at demystifying memes and they have come up with some interesting observations. The meme scientists observed that each meme submitted on Reddit's reposted an average of seven times.

Interestingly, most of the reposts have gone on to garner popularity while the originals languished in obscurity. The scientists have figured out that Reddit has a memory of 45 days, following which there is less chance of encountering negative reactions to a repost and a greater chance of success. Moreover, lunchtime in North America is the best window to post memes on Reddit, as it gives a higher chance of positive exposure. Yes, I realise that the scientific study essentially recommends reposting memes for success. That may sound dishonest but, then again, memes themselves use imitation as a primary means of propagation, so it's all fair game in the end. 

